

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Python leads at 21.25% · C surges to #2 · Go drops from 7th to 16th

METHODOLOGY

The TIOBE Programming Community Index measures language popularity via search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites. Updated monthly since 2001. It does not measure code volume or quality — only how much a language is discussed and sought after online.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Full Top-20 Rankings · March 2026 vs. March 2025

#	Pre March 2025	Language	Rating	YoY
1	—	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	▲2	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	▼1	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	▼1	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	—	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	—	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	▲2	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	—	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	▲7	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	—	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%

#	Pre March 2025	Language	Rating	YoY
11	▲1 3	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	—	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	▼2	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	—	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	—	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	▼9	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	—	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	▼5	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	▼1	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	▲6	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

21.25%

Python rating
(2× second place)

+2.02%

C year-over-year
gain (#4 → #2)

48.97%

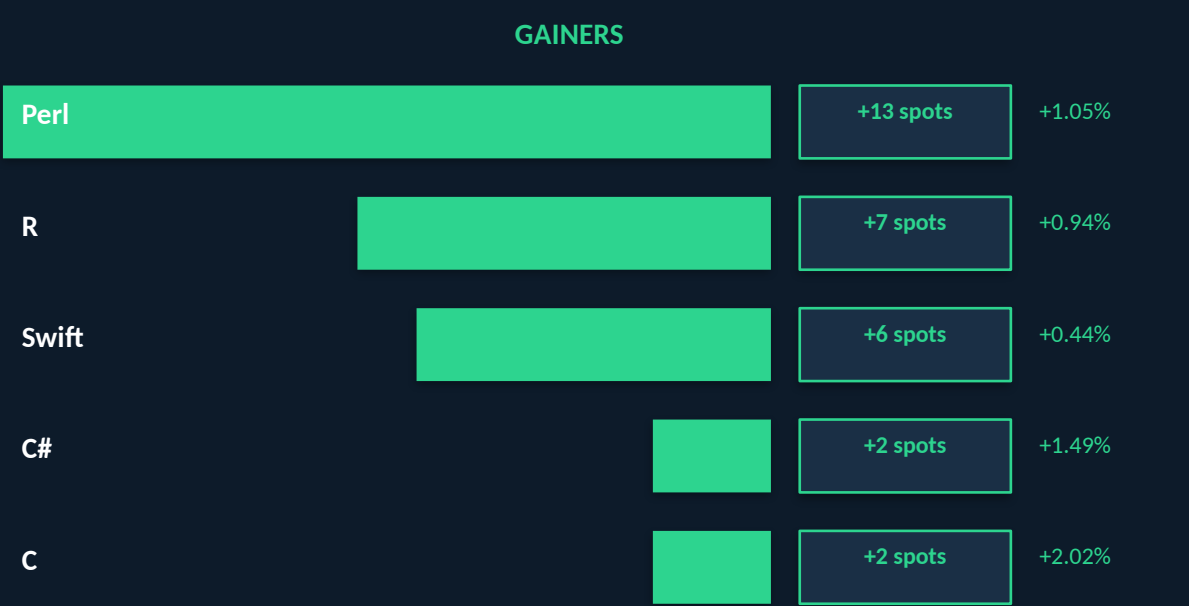
Top-4 share of
total index

-2.59%

Python's YoY
decline (largest top-5)

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Year-over-year rank changes: March 2025 → March 2026



Key insight: Go's -9-spot collapse suggests displacement by Rust in systems programming, while Perl & R demonstrate that legacy languages serving entrenched scientific communities remain resilient.

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Rank snapshots every 5 years across four decades • 2002–2026 trend summary

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python

Unranked in 1986 → #1 in 2026. Surpassed Java post-2018, peaked >25%, now at 21.25%.

C

Only language ranked #1 or #2 across all nine measurement points spanning 40 years.

Java

Dominated 2005–2018 at 25%+. Steady decline to 7.99% — still #4, but a long fall.

Lisp

#2 in 1986, now #26. A cautionary tale: ecosystem stagnation erodes community mindshare.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

TIOBE 'Language of the Year' — largest rating gain in that calendar year



Note: 2017 winner not available in source data.



The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Actionable implications for hiring, training, and tooling decisions

Python Dominates but Declines

At 21.25%, Python leads by 2×. Yet its -2.59 pp YoY drop is the largest among top-5. Maintain Python investment — but monitor the trend. Evaluate whether C's surge signals a shift back to low-level systems work in your stack.

C's Resurgence Is Real

C jumped from #4 to #2 with +2.02 pp — the top gainer. Combined with Rust at #14 (+0.09%), systems-level programming is regaining mindshare. Embedded, OS, and performance-critical teams should plan for increased C/Rust talent demand.

Legacy Languages Aren't Dead

Perl (+13 spots), R (+7 spots), and Fortran (still top-15) defy write-offs. Scientific computing, genomics, and data-pipeline teams still run on these. Avoid abrupt re-platforming without assessing the real cost to entrenched communities.

Go's 9-Spot Drop Is a Warning

Go fell from #7 to #16 in one year — the steepest decline in the top 20. If Go is central to your microservices strategy, assess whether Rust or other alternatives are drawing community energy away. Watch TIOBE over the next 2 quarters.

Concentration Risk: 49% in 4 Languages

Python + C + C++ + Java = 48.97% of all TIOBE ratings. Betting your hiring pipeline on only these four is efficient today but fragile long-term. Build polyglot capability. C# (6.36%, 2× Language of the Year) and Rust (1.31%, rising) are credible next bets.